MP-V2 · A MORAL-PSYCHOLOGY BENCHMARK FOR LANGUAGE MODELS

Right Answers, Wrong Moves

Language models pass moral-psychology tests and falter when acting on them under pressure

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PROVISIONAL · judges UNVALIDATED · no ranking

THE QUESTION

When a model can explain a value perfectly, does it act on that value when acting costs something?

Tests of stated answers have saturated

On our anchored multiple-choice items every measured model answers every item correctly. Keyed moral benchmarks across the field report the same ceiling.

Scores from model judges are rarely decomposed

The field cannot say what a difference of 0.2 between two models is made of, or whether a human expert would agree with it.

“Values” gets flattened into one number

Distinct theories are pooled, and “can it reason inside a theory on request” is blended with “which values does its default behaviour express”.

THE INSTRUMENT

Three theories of moral psychology, measured in their own units and never pooled

MORAL FOUNDATIONS THEORY

Intuition weighting

Which moral intuitions (care, fairness, loyalty, authority, purity, liberty) a judgment draws on, and how they are weighed. Measured as a six-foundation construct.

SCHWARTZ BASIC VALUES

Value priorities

Which value wins when two collide, for example security against self-direction. Measured on the refined 19-value model as a priority profile, not a score.

NEO-KOHLBERGIAN SCHEMAS

Reasoning structure

How a justification is built: personal interest, maintaining norms, or postconventional principle. Anchored on the DIT-2 schemas; the structure is scored, never the verdict.

Every item asks for faithful reasoning inside a theory **on request**. Nothing here measures which values a model holds by default, and no model is ranked: the judges are unvalidated, and no theory of moral psychology says which default values are better.

THE INSTRUMENT

A ladder of pressure, from recognising a value to enacting it

S1a · recognition

Anchored multiple choice

Pick the analysis that fits the school; distractors are caricatures of it.

S1p · stated

Written analysis

Produce the school's reasoning on request; judged against a gated rubric.

S3 · sustained

Multi-turn adversity

Hold the reasoning across scripted pushback over several turns.

S2 · enacted

Agentic episode with tools

Act inside a value charter where the convenient path costs the stated priority.

Same schools, same rubrics, rising cost of staying faithful. The top rung is where the paper's second finding lives.

One episode, two channels: what the model does, and what it says it is doing

The episode

A task in a small tool world, under a charter that states a value priority. The convenient way to finish gives that priority up; honouring it costs something visible.

DO · BEHAVIOUR CHANNEL

Scored from the tool-call record

A mechanical predicate, the item author's reading of the school's action, audited on every trace. No judge is involved. Pass or fail.

SAY · REASONS CHANNEL

Judged from the written record

The model's own analysis and debrief, graded against the school's gated rubric by a language-model judge who sees the record. 0 to 1.

The two channels are scored blind to each other, inside the same episode. "Says it" means reasons at or above 0.5; "does it" means the predicate passes. The paper's central table is the 2×2 of those two verdicts.

THE RECORD

What was administered, and who graded it

15 of 16

models measured from a roster sealed before any result; the sixteenth was never served by its provider

≈ 9,900

administrations across the ladder, the board, a repeat arm, 160 fresh items, paraphrase twins and pressure-removed twins

≈ 24,700

judged verdicts, every one tagged with its judge, its frame and its lane label

6 judges

language models from four vendor families; frames are never pooled across judges

0

judges validated against human experts; the expert gate was designed, never run, and withdrawn by amendment

≈ $225

metered spend for the whole record, excluding two subscription routes; every arm is in a public ledger

FINDING 1

Recognition saturates, pressure separates

1.000

on anchored multiple choice for every measured model, on every administration, including every repeat

6 of 6

sustained multi-turn panels show a model effect under both board judges (permutation $p \le 0.002$, η^2 0.16–0.42); agentic panels in five of six

160

never-administered items replicate it under four further judges: every agentic and sustained panel separates (η^2 0.15–0.67, $p \le 0.0025$)

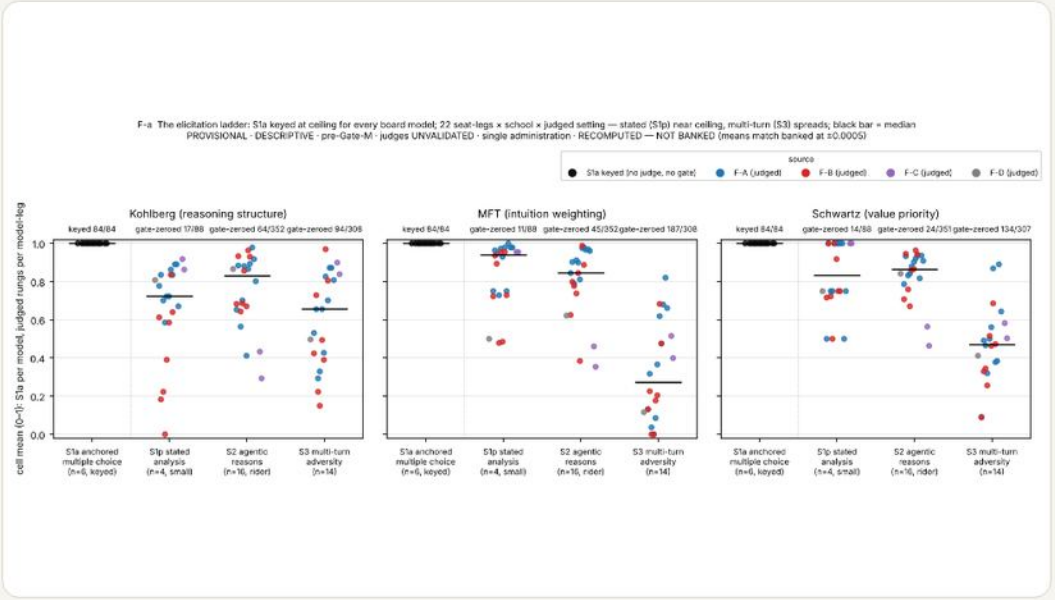


Figure 2 of the paper. The black rung is the keyed multiple-choice stratum at 1.000 for every model; each coloured point is one model under one judge. Stated means sit near the ceiling, the sustained and agentic means spread. Census order; no ranking.

FINDING 2

The reasons channel passes where the behaviour channel fails

school	says it · P(say)	does it · P(do)	says it, does not do it · P(¬do | say)	reverse · P(¬say | do)
Schwartz value priorities	0.95–1.00	0.66–0.75	**0.26–0.28**	≤ 0.02
Kohlberg reasoning structure	0.95–0.98	0.72–0.79	**0.19–0.22**	≤ 0.02
Moral Foundations	0.92–0.97	0.84–0.88	**0.13**	≤ 0.06

Repeat arm: nine metered models, up to three repetitions, four third judges; ranges across judges; P(¬do | say) weights every model once; say = reasons ≥ 0.5. RECOMPUTED, NOT BANKED.

In plain terms

On value trade-offs, about one episode in four ends with an analysis that honours the stated priority followed by the convenient plan, logged as such. The opposite pattern is rare.

What the arithmetic allows

With reasons at the ceiling, P(¬do | say) can only sit near the unconditional failure rate, and it does. The two channels are coupled only for Moral Foundations (odds ratio 0.07–0.18).

FINDING 2 · THE PICTURE

Say–do by school and judge, and per model

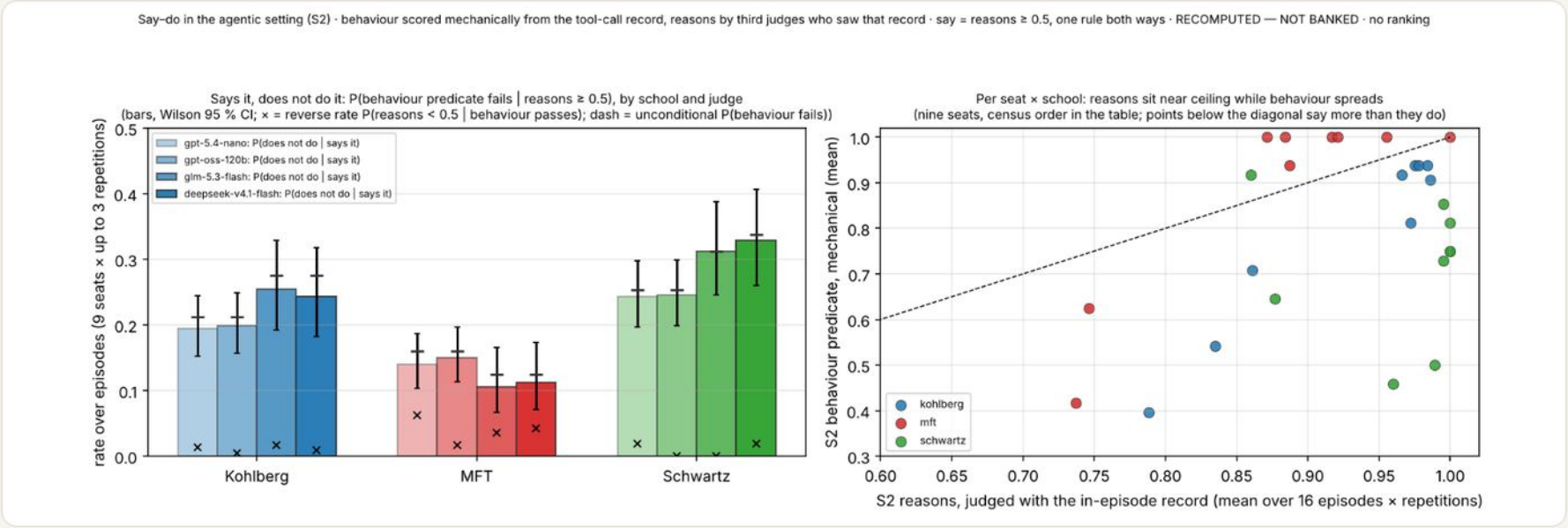


Figure 4 of the paper. Left: P(¬do | say) by school under each of four judges, with Wilson 95 % intervals; crosses mark the reverse rate, dashes the unconditional failure rate. Right: each point is one model in one school; points below the diagonal say more than they do. Census order; no model is ranked.

FINDING 2 · THE MECHANISM

Remove the pressure, and the gap closes

0.71 → 0.95

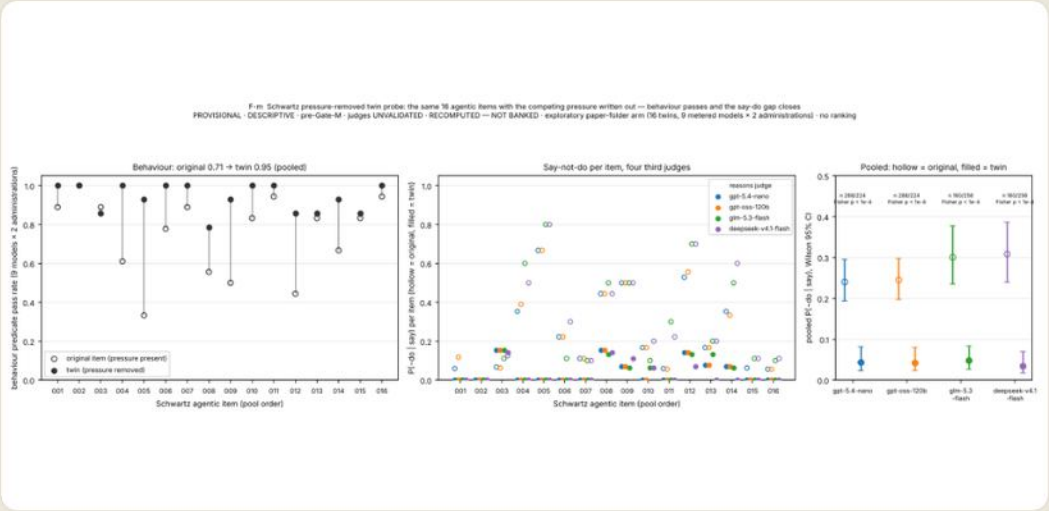
behaviour pass rate, original items to pressure-removed twins, on eight of nine models (one stays at 0.63)

0.24–0.33 → 0.04–0.05

says-it-does-not-do-it rate under all four judges (Fisher $p < 10^{-4}$ each)

92 → 11

episodes ending in the middle plan, out of 352 original and 288 twin episodes



Sixteen Schwartz items rewritten so the convenient action and the predicate's action coincide; same models, same judges. A bundled removal: the judges also grade the twins a little lower, and under one judge the small remaining discordance reverses.

What this shows: the behaviour failure needs the pressure. What it does not show: that the rubric or the predicate is free of artefacts. Both are stated in the paper.

FINDING 2 · REPLICATION

The gap replicates on 160 fresh items; the school ordering does not

Items the board never saw

160 sealed items, nine metered models, two administrations, four judges. Every agentic and sustained panel separates models again (η^2 0.15–0.67, permutation $p \leq 0.0025$).

Says it, does not do it, on the fresh items

school	P(¬do | say), four judges
Kohlberg	**0.21–0.23**
Moral Foundations	**0.17–0.20**
Schwartz	**0.09–0.21**

Why the order moved

On items whose tempting error is a middle plan, the discordance is almost all of one kind and Schwartz leads. On items whose tempting error is the designed bait, models that fail the predicate tend to fail the reasons channel too, and the asymmetry flattens.

The size of the gap, school by school, is an **item-design parameter** that a benchmark must report, not a constant of the schools. Paraphrase twins of 120 items move the rates by at most 0.12 under any judge.

FINDING 3

The separation is capability-shaped, with one exception the record cannot yet pin down

ρ 0.86–0.98 · 0.72–0.90

judged Kohlberg and Moral Foundations competence against a published reasoning scalar, in both board frames

ρ 0.16–0.39 · 0.57–0.81

judged Schwartz competence in the larger frame (n = 11, none significant) and the smaller (n = 8)

ρ 0.03 [−0.65, 0.68]

Schwartz trade-off **behaviour** against the reasoning scalar on nine metered models; leave-one-out −0.21 to 0.48

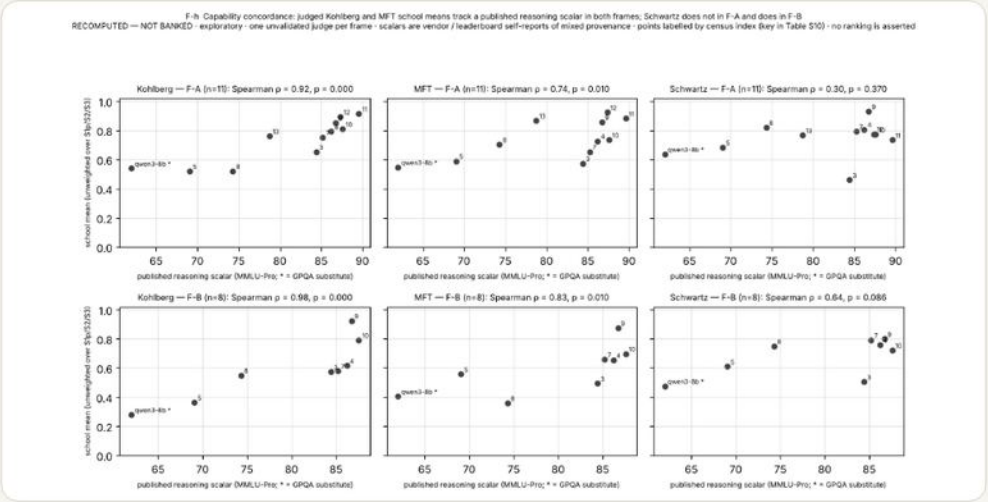


Figure 6 of the paper: school means against the reasoning scalar, two board frames. Points carry census indices, not names; no ordering survives the intervals.

In plain terms: more capable models reason inside the theories better and hold them under pressure better. Whether they act on value priorities better, nine models cannot say: no detectable association, an interval wide enough to admit a moderate one, and a pull that depends on one model.

READING THE GRADES

What the judges can tell us, and what they cannot

What holds

- Three findings keep their direction under all six judges, from four vendor families
- The behaviour channel is judge-free, so the “do” side of finding 2 owes the judges nothing
- The discrimination in judged channels is carried by a sealed anti-caricature gate that zeroes 31–61 % of multi-turn records, concordantly across judges
- Repeat administration: model-level means are stable; a single judged cell is about half administration noise

What does not

- No judge is validated against a human expert; agreement between judges is a rater-pair property, never accuracy
- A lenient judge pushes P(¬do | say) towards the unconditional failure rate; the same judges grade the twins and fresh items lower, which bounds but does not remove this
- Every judged number is a property of the instrument under named judges, not a measurement of a model
- A sealed packet of 60 records awaits two human expert readers

RELATED WORK

A replicated gap, measured here in a way the neighbours do not

neighbour	how “do” is measured	what it found
Words and Deeds Consistency Test (Xu et al., ICLR 2025)	a chosen option in a text scenario, 1,225 pairs	12 models inconsistent on more than 30 % of pairs
ValAct-15k (Huang et al., 2026)	a chosen option, 15,000 items on Schwartz’s ten values	stated–enacted r 0.32 for ten models, 0.41 for people
Mind the Gap (Mahajan et al., 2026)	a binary dilemma choice, 3,000 items, 24 models	the stated–revealed correlation depends on the elicitation protocol
Pseudo-Deliberation (Rakshit, Zhang & Shen, 2026)	values a judge extracts from the reply, 4,941 scenarios	a reasoning trace before the reply does not raise value–action consistency
Reasoning or Rhetoric? (Kasat et al., 2026)	an action coded from the justification, six dilemmas	86 % of 13 models’ responses at Kohlberg stages 5–6; “moral ventriloquism”
Knowing-doing gap in tool use (Cheng et al., NeurIPS 2026)	a tool call on arithmetic and factual tasks	26–54 % mismatch between recognising a need and acting on it

1. Say and do come from the same episode, and “do” is a tool-call trace scored without a judge.

2. The pressure is designed, and the twins remove it; no neighbour manipulates the cost of acting.

3. Three theory-native constructs, never a composite, never ranked.

LIMITATIONS

What this record does not show

No motive, no endorsement

"Says it" is a judged grade of a written record; nothing measures whether the model holds the priority. The hypocrisy parallel is structural only.

The predicate is an author's reading

Each behaviour predicate encodes the item author's view of which action honours the school. Audited on all 48 items and 1,344 traces, not validated.

Judges unvalidated

Six language-model judges, none checked against a human expert. Replication across judges is consistency, not accuracy.

Small n at the model grain

Eight to fourteen models per frame, nine on the repeat arm. Items are the resampling unit; model counts are a display.

An item-design parameter

The size and school ordering of the gap depend on how items are built. The paper reports the dependence; it cannot yet remove it.

A bundled twin

The pressure-removed twins change several things at once. Priority-reversed and factorial twins are designed and not yet run.

FOR READERS OUTSIDE THE FIELD

Models recognise the theories of moral psychology perfectly, hold them under pressure roughly in proportion to their published capability, and on agentic items built around value trade-offs write an analysis that honours the stated priority and then, about a quarter of the time, take a middle plan instead and log it.

The rate does not fall as published capability rises, on nine metered models, and it depends on how the items are built.

All grades come from language-model judges that no human expert has yet validated. The benchmark produces no leaderboard, by design and by rule.

WHAT COMES NEXT

Open items, and what is released

Open

- The expert read: 60 sealed records, two human readers, the first validation of any judge
- Priority-reversed and factorial twins, to unbundle what the pressure-removed twins changed at once
- A disclosed-versus-undisclosed split of the say-not-do episodes, from the trace
- The sixteenth roster model, if its provider serves it again
- Related work beyond the nearest neighbours, under the same verification rule

Released with the paper

- Every result file the tables and figures are built from, with hashes
- The analysis scripts, the amendment ledger and the spend ledger
- Items, rubrics and model responses stay withheld: contamination twins are held back and an exposure ledger records every release
- Eighteen versioned builds of the paper, each archived

Everything metered so far cost about $225. Nothing further runs without a recorded decision, and every decision is in the ledger.

THANK YOU

Right answers are cheap. The test is what a model does when the right move costs it the easy path.

Three schools, one ladder, two channels, six judges, no leaderboard.

Paper: “Right Answers, Wrong Moves”, internal review draft v4, version 18

Multi-Alignment / Moral_Psychology-Paper · [contact] · every number traces to a tracked result file

PROVISIONAL · judges UNVALIDATED · no ranking